Evidence cards on the causes of war

Tuesday 5 January 2027 | P2 | 40 minutes | Year A

Humanities | LAUNCH | Spring 1 Week 1 | HUM-LAUNCH-S1-W01

Pink paper version. Read quietly, point, write, type, speak privately or direct a scribe. You may pass. No public answer or reading aloud is required.

Teacher-written factual summary for learning. This is not an archive extract or testimony. No real person is quoted.

S1 to S4 form the core set. S5 is an optional extension. Source codes identify these summaries. They do not turn them into original historical sources.

S1 Treaty and resentment

28 June 1919

The Treaty of Versailles was a peace agreement signed between Germany and the Allied powers on 28 June 1919. It took territory from Germany, limited its armed forces and required reparations, payments for war damage. Many Germans resented the terms. Nazi leaders later used this anger to win support for overturning the settlement.

Resentment gave Nazi leaders an issue to exploit. The treaty alone did not make another war inevitable.

Think: How did this factor change the risk of war?

Research basis: H1, H2.

S2 Nazi rule and expansion

30 January 1933 and after

Adolf Hitler was appointed chancellor of Germany on 30 January 1933. The Nazis then destroyed democracy and built a dictatorship. Nazi leaders sought more territory and racist domination in eastern Europe. They rebuilt Germany's armed forces and made choices that increased the danger of war.

Nazi aims and decisions drove aggression. Responsibility belongs to decision makers and participants, not every German person.

Think: How did this factor change the risk of war?

Research basis: H3, H4.

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S3 Concessions failed to stop expansion

September 1938 to March 1939

At Munich in September 1938, Britain and France accepted Germany's takeover of the Sudetenland, part of Czechoslovakia. They hoped concessions would avoid war. In March 1939, German forces occupied the Czech lands of Bohemia and Moravia. The concessions had not ended Nazi expansion.

Appeasement aimed to prevent war but failed to stop further aggression. This response did not remove Nazi leaders' responsibility.

Think: How did this factor change the risk of war?

Research basis: H4, H5.

S4 Invasion and the immediate trigger

1 and 3 September 1939

Nazi Germany invaded Poland on 1 September 1939. Britain and France had promised to support Poland. They declared war on Germany on 3 September after Germany did not withdraw. The invasion triggered a wider war in Europe.

The invasion was the immediate trigger. Earlier causes help explain why this crisis developed.

Think: How did this factor change the risk of war?

Research basis: H6.

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S5 An enabling agreement

23 August 1939

Nazi Germany and the Soviet Union made a non-aggression pact. A secret part divided areas of eastern Europe into spheres of influence. Hitler could attack Poland with less immediate risk of Soviet opposition. The agreement helped enable the invasion.

This is an additional enabling factor. It does not mean the two states shared every aim.

Think: How did this factor change the risk of war?

Research basis: H7.

Careful context for later learning

Jewish people had varied ordinary lives, families and communities. Nazi antisemitism, prejudice and hatred directed at Jews, led to persecution before the war began. The Holocaust was the systematic persecution and murder of six million European Jews by Nazi Germany and its allies and collaborators. War and the Holocaust are connected, but they are not the same event. Nazi policy and human choices matter. Later lessons examine this carefully.

History evidence can help explain harmful choices. It does not excuse them. You may ask for a private pause or choose the neutral date-order task.